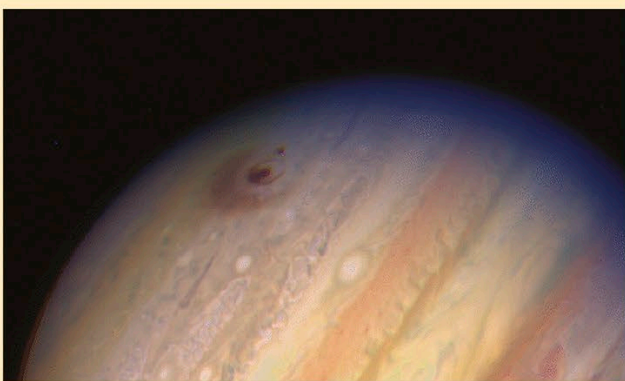


Comets and meteors

In between the planets, space contains gas, dust, icy comets, and rocks called asteroids. Comets, which can be thought of as space snowballs, vary in size. When one moves close to the Sun, the Sun's heat turns its ice to gas, and dust is released. The gas and dust form a huge head (coma), and two tails – one of gas, the other of dust. If the head and tails are bright enough, they can be seen from the Earth.

Collision course

In 1994, a ball of fire the size of a small planet exploded on Jupiter. It happened when the first of more than 20 fragments of a comet ploughed into the planet.



Crash landing

When comet Shoemaker-Levy 9 collided with Jupiter, it was the biggest collision of two solar system bodies observed by humankind.

Comet Shoemaker-Levy 9 sent fireballs more than 3,000 km (1,900 miles) above the clouds of Jupiter.